

I want to be clear: Pushing for greater parity in a prenup because you have to give up a job or leave the country or take care of children in this new partnership isn't gold-digging. This is smart premarital negotiating. But if you're concerned only about your cut in case the marriage ends, you should both know what you're getting into.

Even a true gold digger deserves a little financial advice. Here's mine: I suggest that you learn a skill as part of your exit strategy—and you know you have one, probably many. Get your real estate license or some chef training, because those are the kinds of jobs that pay well and require really good contacts, which you'll have. Your backup plan should go beyond getting a cut of someone's wealth, especially if you haven't contributed anything to building it. It should include how you're going to build your own wealth if, or when, things fall apart.

## **How to Spot a Gold Digger**

Not every beautiful young man or woman you meet is out for your money. But I advise you to padlock your wallet or call a lawyer if you are dating people with these characteristics:

- They seem to live beyond their means.
- They have no discernible employment or goals in life beyond being available to you.
- They bring up money way too soon.
- They expect you to pay for everything.
- They wear expensive clothes and jewelry they can't seem to afford.
- They constantly hint at things they'd like you to purchase or pay for.
- They're willing to date someone a lot older and a lot uglier than they are.
- They're cagey about discussing their future or their past, especially other wealthy people they have dated.
- They're less interested in you if you stanch the flow of funds or free stuff.
- They won't sign a prenup.